Chandela Religion and Its Tantric Substrate

The religion that emerged at Khajuraho, writes Desai, was ‘a synthesis of two religious orders, Tantric and Puranic, resulting in a Miśra (mixed or composite) religion’, which included ‘Vedic mantras and caste-order along with the Tantric mode of worship’.[36]

Tantrism started acquiring prominence in north India in mid-first millennium CE, though its roots go back to ‘prehistoric concepts of a fertile mother goddess and ancient systems for her worship’. It resisted a precise definition because it never became ‘a coherent system’ and remained a cluster of ideas and practices with a family resemblance. ‘Tantrism’ itself is a modern Western term that, like ‘Hinduism’, is not indigenous to the tradition.

In the late twentieth century, Tantrism entered the New Age culture in the West and got a boost from gurus like Osho. Alas, the dominant idea of Tantrism in the West today—packaged as an exotic regimen to heighten sexual pleasure—is quite reductive. It’s a pale shadow of its full expression in ancient India, when it was a lot more than exotic sexual practices.

Most ancient practitioners of Tantra likely recognized what they did ‘as different from the Vedic tradition’.[37] But while it was mainly a heterodox system, it fused and coexisted with older norms and beliefs in many Vedic and non-Vedic faiths, such as Shaivism, Vaishnavism, Shaktism, Buddhism and Jainism. In other words, between 500 and 1300 CE, most self-professed Vaishnavites and Shaivites, alongside pursuing many orthodox Brahminical and mystical–devotional practices, also pursued, *along a spectrum*, various Tantric practices. As usual, folk religiosity cared little for the neat boundaries and fine distinctions of theologians. It freely mixed ideas, practices and rituals based largely on their utility towards tangible ends, such as worldly benefits, social bonding, creating purpose and meaning, relief from woes and misfortunes, emotional comfort and justification for their choices, and so on.

What distinguished Tantrism from Brahminism, Buddhism and Jainism? The idea that worldly temptations, cravings and physical desires are impediments to spiritual growth and enlightenment was central to the latter three, so they idealized asceticism and renunciation. At Nalanda, for